Social Media: Hashtags

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What is it for?

Imagine trying to read a sentence where all the spaces have been removed. It would look like a jumble of letters that takes real effort to decipher. That is exactly what a screen reader encounters when it reads a hashtag written entirely in lowercase.

If you write #superbowl, a screen reader might read it as "Superb Owl" rather than "Super Bowl". By capitalising the first letter of each word, we give the technology a clear signal of where one word ends and the next begins. This ensures the hashtag is pronounced correctly and is easier for everyone to read visually.

How to support it

Make hashtags accessible with a few simple adjustments.

- Always capitalise the first letter of every word, like '#SocialMediaMarketing'. This helps screen readers pronounce words correctly and improves clarity
- Keep your hashtags short. Combining too many words makes them difficult to process, even with capital letters
- Place hashtags at the very end of your post. Don't put them in the middle of a sentence, as this disrupts the reading flow for assistive technology users

Useful Links

Accessible Social

RNIB - How to make your social media accessible

Hootsuite - Inclusive Design for Social Media